New 'Street Fighter' movie gets attention for its surprising cast

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A new "Street Fighter" movie, based on the famous fighting video game, arrived in theaters this weekend. Much of the excitement around it has come from its very unusual mix of actors, according to a writer at the entertainment site IndieWire.

The movie comes from the companies Legendary, Capcom and Paramount. Some of its **cast** choices seem expected for an action film, such as Noah Centineo, Andrew Koji and Jason Momoa. But the **cast** also includes WWE wrestlers Roman Reigns and Cody Rhodes, comedians Andrew Schulz and Eric Andre, country singer Orville Peck, and rapper Curtis "50 Cent" Jackson as a boxer.

The writer said he never expected to care about a new "Street Fighter" movie. He only remembered playing the **arcade** game a little. But as each surprising name was announced, he grew more curious about how such different performers would work together on screen. He called the finished movie "a **mixed bag**," but said it is never boring, partly because the **cast** looks excited to be there.

The movie is set in 1993. The writer asks whether "**meme** casting**," or choosing an unexpected group of famous people that gets fans talking online, could become a new way for Hollywood to sell movies. For years,** studios **have counted on well-known characters, not star actors, to bring in audiences, but that has not always worked.**

The film was expected to earn as much as $70 million around the world in its opening weekend. It cost about $82 million to make. The writer says it is too early to know whether the **casting** is the main reason, since the game is already well known and the movie received mixed **reviews**.

Word Treasure

cast -- A cast is the group of actors who perform in a movie, play or show.

arcade -- An arcade is a place with coin-operated video games, or a game made for one.

meme casting -- Meme casting means choosing an unexpected mix of famous people so fans talk and joke about it online.

mixed bag -- A mixed bag is something that has both good parts and bad parts.

studios -- Studios are companies that make and release movies.

reviews -- Reviews are opinions written by critics about whether a movie, book or show is good.

Background you need

Street Fighter is a famous fighting video game series in which players choose characters with special moves and battle each other.

Movie studios often turn popular games, comics and books into films because fans already know the characters.

Casting means choosing which actors will play each role, and surprising choices can get people talking before a film opens.

A movie's opening weekend earnings are often compared with its budget to judge how well it may do.

Break it down

LEAD: The new "Street Fighter" movie is getting attention for its unusual cast.
KEY EVENT: The video game film arrives in theaters this weekend
+- WHO: Legendary, Capcom and Paramount; actors, wrestlers, comedians and musicians
+- WHEN: Set in 1993
OPINION: An IndieWire writer calls it "a mixed bag" but never boring
BIG IDEA: Could "meme casting" become a new way to sell movies?
EVIDENCE: Expected opening of up to $70 million worldwide against an $82 million budget
OPEN QUESTION: Is the casting the main reason, given the well-known game and mixed reviews?

Why it matters

The story shows how movie studios try new ways to attract audiences when famous characters alone no longer guarantee success.

Test what you remember

1. What is the new movie based on?

(A) A board game
(B) A comic book
(C) A TV cartoon
(D) A famous fighting video game

2. Which WWE wrestlers are in the cast?

(A) Roman Reigns and Cody Rhodes
(B) Jason Momoa and Noah Centineo
(C) Orville Peck and 50 Cent
(D) Eric Andre and Andrew Schulz

3. What role does Curtis "50 Cent" Jackson play?

(A) A game-show host
(B) A boxer
(C) A wrestler
(D) A teacher

4. How did the IndieWire writer describe the finished movie?

(A) A perfect film
(B) A remake of an old cartoon
(C) Too scary for anyone
(D) "A mixed bag" that is never boring

5. In what year is the movie set?

(A) 1993
(B) 2010
(C) 2026
(D) 1987

6. About how much did the movie cost to make?

(A) $82 million
(B) $7 million
(C) $200 million
(D) $70 million

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. IndieWire writer: Thinks the movie is a mixed bag but never boring, and wonders whether surprising casting helps sell movies.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):